

Musical expression

The beauty of a musical performance lies in the infinite variety of ways in which performers can produce sounds. In a similar way, composers can indicate subtle variations in the sounds they want by using certain symbols.

SEE ALSO

◀ 34–35 Rests and ties

◀ 42–43 Tempo

The note connection

Musicians can make their sounds separate, or elongated and attached. **Staccato**—marked by a dot beneath or above the note head—means the tones should be short and distinct. **Legato**—a curved line over or under the notes—indicates that the notes should be played smoothly, without breaks in the sound.



78

◀ Staccato

These notes, marked staccato (Italian for “detached”), should sound clipped and distinct, with a space between each tone.



79

◀ Legato

Legato (Italian for “tied together”) are notes that are played smoothly, and connected with one air stream, bow stroke, or hand motion.

GLOSSARY

Playing with time

Altering the pace, or tempo, of music, can drastically change the mood and character of a piece. Composers have specific ways of doing this. Think of the effect produced when a musician slows down the last few seconds of a musical piece to signal winding

it down, and finally ending it. Alternatively, think of how exciting and rowdy a gradual increase in the speed would sound. Composers have specific terms that indicate to performers the desired musical effect.

ritardando

△ Ritardando or rallentando

Slowing down the speed of music is known as ritardando or rallentando (abbreviated rit. and rall. respectively).

rallentando

accelerando

△ Accelerando

Speeding up the tempo of music, or getting faster, is called an accelerando (abbreviated accel.).

a tempo

△ A tempo

After changing the speed, a tempo indicates that performers should revert to the original pace.